

THE ROOT

To every soul living through war, occupation, persecution,
displacement, famine, violence, or fear. This is not politics.

This is love.

Your home may be destroyed.

Your school may be gone.

Your hospital may be gone.

Your place of worship may be gone.

Your neighborhood may become rubble.

Your family may be separated.

Your loved ones may have died.

Your belongings may be taken.

But they cannot destroy the truth that you exist.

They cannot erase your humanity. They cannot destroy your
essence. Buildings can be demolished. Cities can fall.

Empires can collapse. Truth remains.

No act of destruction can erase your existence.

You are loved.

A monster never arrives with fangs.

It arrives with a badge, a neighborhood watch,

a jury, a camera, or a courtroom.

It says, "I feared for my life."

Her tears fell like acid, dissolving truth wherever they landed.

They looked like grief. They carried the weight of accusation.

They left devastation in their wake.

The smile came first. Then the trembling voice.

Then the words.

"I was afraid."

The room grew silent.

Another heartbeat became evidence. Another life became a
headline. The monster never bared its teeth. It borrowed a human
face. Then the person lying motionless on the pavement is the
one who never gets to explain theirs.

The streets become haunted by names instead of ghosts.

Families memorize final phone calls instead of bedtime stories.

Children learn that daylight does not always mean safety.

The horror is not only the death.

The horror is hearing the same sentence echo
after another body falls.

"I feared for my life."

The victim is gone, the witness is grieving,
the cameras recorded it, the world watched it.

The nightmare keeps asking the living
to prove they deserved to survive.

FRED HAMPTON

Fred Hampton was born on August 30th 1948 in Chicago Illinois.

By the time he was 20 years old he was the Chairman of the Illinois Chapter of the Black Panther Party. He was one of the most gifted organizers and speakers Black America had ever produced. He was murdered.

He negotiated peace treaties between rival Chicago street gangs.

He built a free breakfast program that fed hundreds of Black children every morning before school.

He organized poor white communities alongside poor Black communities under a coalition he called the Rainbow Coalition.

He was building cross racial unity at a time when that was considered revolutionary and dangerous.

The FBI under J Edgar Hoover identified Fred Hampton as a potential Black Messiah. Someone so charismatic and effective that if left unchecked he could unite poor people across racial lines and fundamentally change the power structure of America.

So they killed him.

An FBI informant named William O'Neal infiltrated the Black Panther Party and became Fred Hampton's bodyguard and personal driver. O'Neal drugged Fred Hampton's drink on the night of December 3rd 1969. Then provided the FBI with a detailed floor plan of the apartment including the exact location of Fred Hampton's bed.

At 4 am on December 4th 1969 Chicago police officers working with the FBI raided the apartment. They fired over 90 rounds into the apartment. Fred Hampton was shot twice in the head at point blank range while he was unconscious in his bed from the drugs he had been given.

He was 21 years old.

His pregnant girlfriend Akua Njeri was lying next to him.

She survived.

Their son Fred Hampton Jr was born 25 days later.

He never met his father.

DOCUMENTED RACIAL TERROR

The Colfax Massacre (1873): White supremacists murdered approximately 150 African Americans in Louisiana.

Mary Turner (1918): An 8-month pregnant Black woman who was lynched, burned, and mutilated by a white mob in Georgia after she publicly protested the lynching of her husband.

The Tulsa Race Massacre (1921): A white mob destroyed the Greenwood district in Oklahoma, killing an estimated 75 to 300 Black residents.

The Elaine Massacre Victims (1919): An estimated 100 to 240 Black sharecroppers were slaughtered by white mobs and federal troops in Arkansas after attempting to unionize.

The Rosewood Massacre (1923): A racially motivated attack by a white mob completely destroyed a Black town in Florida, killing multiple residents.

Harry and Harriette Moore (1951): Civil rights activists who were assassinated when a bomb planted by the Ku Klux Klan exploded under their bedroom in Florida on Christmas night.

Lamar Smith (1955): A civil rights activist and voting rights advocate who was murdered by gunshot in broad daylight on a Mississippi courthouse lawn just weeks before Emmett Till was murdered. No one was ever convicted.

The brutal murder of 14-year-old Emmett Till in Mississippi in 1955 remains one of the most infamous catalysts of the Civil Rights Movement. His death belonged to a continuous, documented lineage of racial terror lynchings and white supremacist violence that occurred both decades before and decades after his murder.

Before 1955, thousands of Black Americans were murdered by white mobs and law enforcement, with complete impunity.

The infrastructure of racial violence continued immediately after Till's death, targeting both high-profile civil rights leaders and everyday Black citizens.

Mack Charles Parker (1959): Dragged from his jail cell in Mississippi by a white mob and lynched days before he was set to stand trial for a disputed accusation.

Medgar Evers (1963): An NAACP field secretary and WWII veteran who was assassinated in his own driveway in Jackson, Mississippi, by a white supremacist.

The 16th Street Baptist Church Victims (1956): Four young Black girls, Addie Mae Collins (14), Denise McNair (11), Carole Robertson (14), and Cynthia Wesley (14), who were killed when the Ku Klux Klan bombed a church in Birmingham, Alabama.

James Chance, Michael Schwerner, and Andrew Goodman (1964):
Three civil rights workers (one Black, two white) who were
abducted and murdered by the Ku Klux Klan in Mississippi during
the "Freedom Summer" voting registration drive.

James Byrd Jr. (1998): A 49-year-old Black man who was targeted,
beaten, and dragged to his death behind a pickup truck by three
white supremacists in Jasper, Texas.

The full timeline of these historical atrocities is thoroughly
preserved and searchable through

the Equal Justice Initiative's Legacy Museum archives
and the Library of Congress Civil Rights History Project

The Mapping Police Violence Database tracks law enforcement
killings from 2013 through 2026. It documents more than 1,000
cases annually, detailing names, locations, and racial data.

The Equal Justice Initiative (EJI) Registry maps and lists names
for nearly 6,500 documented racial terror lynchings perpetrated
by white mobs between 1865 and 1950.

The Wikipedia List of Lynching Victims in the United States
serves as a collaboratively compiled,
documented index organized chronologically by state.

LIVES STOLEN BY LAW ENFORCEMENT

Independent tracking organizations like the Mapping Police Violence Report analyze police narratives (where language about drug use or aggressive behavior is most frequently documented).

Their data reveals:

Black people murdered by police are statistically less likely to be threatening someone at the time of their death compared to white individuals.

Across analyzed police killings,

Black people are significantly more likely to be unarmed. Black Americans consistently account for more than a quarter of all fatal police shootings, and over one-third of unarmed victims.

When looking broadly at how deaths are categorized under "gun violence" vs. "gang activity," federal data disproves the narrative that the vast majority of Black homicide victims are killed in gang-related turf wars or drug disputes: According to the Violence Policy Center, for homicides where the relationship and circumstances are officially identified, 77% of Black victims were killed by someone they knew. More than 80% of these deaths were completely unrelated to the commission of another felony (such as drug trafficking or robbery).

Instead, 56.1% stemmed from arguments.

While gang violence officially accounts for 5% of Black homicides according to the Bureau of Justice Statistics, firearms are used in 77% of all homicides against Black victims, compared to 60% for white victims.

Research shows that when a Black individual is murdered, early police reports and media coverage disproportionately highlight minor past offenses, any trace of substances found in toxicology reports, or loose associations with neighborhood groups to implicitly justify the use of force.

Even though Black and white Americans use illicit substances at virtually identical rates, Black Americans are four times more likely to be arrested for drug violations. This disparity inflates prior arrest records, which are then routinely cited by defense attorneys and media outlets after a fatal encounter to frame the deceased victim as a "dangerous drug user."

George Floyd - murdered by police in Minneapolis in 2020.

Breonna Taylor - murdered during a police raid in Louisville in 2020.

Eric Garner - murdered by an illegal chokehold by police in New York in 2014.

Michael Brown - murdered by gunshot by a police officer in Ferguson, Missouri, in 2014.

MISSING BLACK AMERICANS

More than 100,000 Black Americans are currently missing, accounting for roughly 40% of all missing person cases.

NOLAN WELLS - Nolan Wells traveled by boat to Horn Island to celebrate the Fourth of July with three white high school men.

The three white men returned to the mainland without him, they left in possession of Wells' cell phone and keys. Wells' body was found washed ashore on the island two days later.

TYLER JAY SMITH - Around the same time, 18-year-old Tyler Jay Smith was shot and killed in Lexington, Kentucky.

Smith was hanging out with a group of white men when he sustained a fatal gunshot wound to the head. The individuals present told authorities the shooting was an accident while playing Russian Roulette. While police initially treated it as accidental, one 20-year-old individual, Bryce M. Chestnut, was later charged with tampering with physical evidence for disposing of the firearm.

Kierra Coles (2018): A 26-year-old postal worker from Chicago, Illinois. She was three months pregnant when she vanished after leaving her home on October 2, 2018.

Lashaya Stine (2016): A 16-year-old honors student from Aurora, Colorado. She vanished in the early morning hours of July 15, 2016.

Dawnita Wilkerson (2020): A 44-year-old mother of six from Evansville, Indiana. She disappeared on June 21, 2020, after checking into a local motel.

Rajah Adriana McQueen (2021): A 27-year-old mother of two from Cleveland, Ohio. She was last seen on June 26, 2021, being forced into her own vehicle.

Sacoya Cooper (2021): A 33-year-old mother from Columbus, Ohio. She disappeared on August 31, 2021, after telling family members she was stepping out briefly.

Kelli Allen (2018): A teenager who went missing from Atlanta, Georgia, on December 20, 2018. Like many missing Black minors, her case was categorized

with minimal media urgency by local jurisdictions.

Daniel Robinson (2021): A 24-year-old geologist who went missing from his job site in the desert of Buckeye, Arizona, on June 23, 2021.

The Black and Missing Foundation: You can view active flyers or report a missing loved one directly through the BAMFI Database.

The Charley Project: An extensive public archive detailing over 16,000 "cold case" disappearances,

heavily focusing on cases ignored by the press.

The Ebony Alert is a first-of-its-kind emergency notification system designed to prioritize and accelerate the search for missing Black youth and young women.

How the Ebony Alert Works: It is managed by state agencies like the California Highway Patrol, the system mimics the infrastructure of AMBER Alerts. When activated, it pushes urgent missing person data across electronic highway billboards, local television broadcasts, radio stations, and social media channels. Applies strictly to missing Black individuals, including youth and young women, between the ages of 12 and 25. Can be triggered if the individual disappears under unexplained or suspicious circumstances, is believed to be subject to human or sex trafficking, or suffers from physical or mental disabilities.

The system has shown direct, measurable utility. According to legislative reports, California law enforcement issued 31 Ebony Alerts in its initial deployment period, directly contributing to the successful recovery of 27 individuals.

THE PATTERN DID NOT END

Robert Fuller (2020): A 24-year-old Black man murdered and hung from a tree outside City Hall in Palmdale, California.

Malcolm Harsch (2020): A 38-year-old murdered and hung from a tree in Victorville, California, just ten days prior to Robert Fuller.

Dennoriss Richardson (2024): A community activist murdered and hung in a rural area in Alabama.

Trevonte Jamal Shubert-Helton (2024): A 29-year-old murdered and hung from a tree in a Georgia wildlife management area.

Tory Medley (2025) & Earl Smith (2025): Both men were murdered and hung from trees in Mississippi and New York.

Demartravion "Trey" Reed (2025): A 21-year-old freshman at Delta State University murdered and hung from a tree on campus in Mississippi.

Call these murderers what they are.
I didn't say murder or attack them.
They are murderers.
THE PEOPLE who are will be called by their name.
A LABEL THEY CREATED FOR US,
hidden behind a badge, a mask, a title, a race.
Black American boys are called men
before they are ever allowed to be children.
People who kill our children are described as
"boys" and "young men,"
"girls" and "young women,"
their youth preserved
while their victims' childhood is stripped away.
Call them what they are.
They destroy innocence.
If there had ever been a desire for revolt,
history would have looked very different.
If I wanted revenge against every person who wronged me,
I would not be here speaking about love,
healing, and remembrance.
I am not afraid, nor do I hate the people
who attempted to oppress me or who participated in the
oppression of so many people labeled Black.
"Black" is a label that was assigned.
It is not the totality of who anyone is.
I see fear. Fear of equality.
Fear of losing the illusion of superiority.
No one is born above another.
No one is born beneath another.
The harder someone strives to stand above everyone else,
the further they drift from the equality they claim to defend.
I do not answer fear with fear.
I do not answer hatred with hatred.
I answer it with love, because love requires no pedestal.
This is not a call to violence.
It is a refusal to participate in it.
It is a reminder that every human being stands on the same
ground, regardless of what the label's history assigned them.
Remember your roots!
Acknowledge their story so you don't live recognizing it as your
own.

Donesha Park

